

reducing the most painful costs, especially if you're the one pulling away.

But take it in steps. First, research divorce laws in your state. In North Carolina, for instance, you and your spouse must have lived separate and apart for at least one year before you can divorce. Then, decide with your soon-to-be ex whether mediation can best divide assets and work out custody issues. Do your own photocopying and record-keeping—anything to save money. Put everything in writing, and organize all your assets, income, pensions, debt, investments, and expenses.

When it comes to child support, there are firm tables and guidelines, but these are modifiable. Be generous here. As for property and the marital home, even if you paid for the whole thing, it's usually divided equally. Often, it makes sense for the children to remain with the custodial parent. Some couples even rent separate places where they each live when the children aren't in their primary care. But any money in the children's accounts, such as a trust or any college funds you've set aside, is their money and should remain so.

Seek expert financial guidance to divide any and all assets you've accumulated through investments, property, retirement vehicles, or joint businesses. Don't attempt to do this yourself. Property settlements are final and can't be renegotiated. And don't forget to rewrite and refile a will.

As for working with a lawyer, get a referral from someone you trust, but I suggest you find someone who has a "collaborative practice." This is a relatively new option wherein the lawyer works collaboratively with your soon-to-be ex's lawyer, instead of as an adversary. The goal of a collaborative divorce is to avoid court at all costs, regardless of how acrimonious things might get.

And by all means seek counseling and stay in counseling during the proceedings. It's a good investment that'll go a long way toward reducing the costs of divorce, even years after it's made final. The well-being of any children should always come first.